

Introduction

Every month, Fast Track takes a new journey into the depths of Technology, and delivers to you crisp analysis in a compact, easy-to-digest manner. This month, we're donning our scuba-diving gear and plunging into the ocean of apps. You probably know what Apps are but in case you don't, they're rich programs that you can install on a mobile device such as a smartphone or tablet. They help extend the functionality of your device, ease your life in some way, or simply entertain you wherever you may be. They're all the rage these days; every company, brand and entity wants to have one, and as a result there are millions of apps across multiple mobile platforms. Before the smartphone explosion, you had "feature" phones that had very limited scope of use other than what came inside the box. They started supporting Java's mobile runtime, dubbed J2ME. But there were a bunch of issues with that – first of all, the Java runtime didn't have deep access to the hardware of the phone, thereby limiting the scope of developers. Then there wasn't a centralized place to find apps that would work with your phone – an app store, if you will. You had apps scattered across different websites, making app discovery a tedious affair. Even the revolutionary iPhone didn't have a dedicated App Store in its iOS version 1.0; the company initially thought that developers would make web-apps using modern internet languages. But soon it dawned on them that web-apps couldn't deliver as good an experience on a mobile screen as a native app would. And the rest, as they say, is history.

Following in Apple's footsteps (now there's an often heard phrase), every smartphone OS had an 'App Store' of its own. Today, one of the measures of success for a smartphone OS is the number and variety of apps on its platform.